



Dam on Cape Fear debated

River coveted as a source of water

Associated Press

FAYETTEVILLE — Cumberland County is considering the need for damming the Cape Fear River as it looks ahead to a thirsty and crowded future.

Dam proponents say it could ensure an adequate water supply for the future. Critics counter that the damage dams wreak on the environment is too great and that water quality often suffers when rivers are dammed.

About 1.7 million people live in the state's largest river basin, which stretches from Greensboro to Southport. The Cape Fear River provides drinking water for about 20 percent of the state's residents. The watershed's population is expected to reach 2.1 million by 2020.

Sen. Larry Shaw, D-Cumberland, introduced legislation in March calling for the dam. He said the dam is crucial to Fayetteville's

Photos by TED RICHARDSON/Associated Press

Dr. Rick Beldegreen releases an American bald eagle into Uwharrie National Forest at High Rock Lake near Denton on Sunday. The eagle suffered a gunshot wound in January and spent nearly three months recovering at the Carolina Raptor Center near Charlotte.

Eagle's hard-fought flight

With rehabilitators' help, injured bird back in wild

By KATHLEEN CURRY

Staff Writer

The eagle has flown.

An American bald eagle found shot in January at High Rock Lake went home Sunday.

Staff from the Carolina Raptor Center near Huntersville released the bird, which then soared easily across High Rock Lake before settling into the forest beyond.

As the graceful bird took off, a crowd of onlookers from Charlotte, Greensboro and Winston-Salem cheered. The Carolina Raptor Center directed the launch at High Rock, about 60 miles northeast of Charlotte, after nearly three months of working to save the endangered bird's life.

"It was beautiful," said Alan Barnhardt, director of the CRC. "This was the first eagle in a long, long while we've been able to (heal) and release."

Bald eagles, America's national bird, are endangered and federally protected from harm. This eagle arrived at the CRC after High Rock Lake resident Marvin Tripp called and said a huge bird was tottering about on his property, looking injured.

Assuming it was one of the hundreds of falcons that CRC specialists rescue yearly, volunteer transporter and falconer Bob Pendergrass went out to Tripp's land to pick up the bird.

"He'd told Marvin to put a box over the bird to keep him still.

WANT TO HELP?

Anyone with information on the eagle's shooting should contact Special Agent Sandra Allred of the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service at (919) 856-4786, Ext. 34. For more information on the Carolina Raptor Center, visit www.BirdsOfPrey.org.

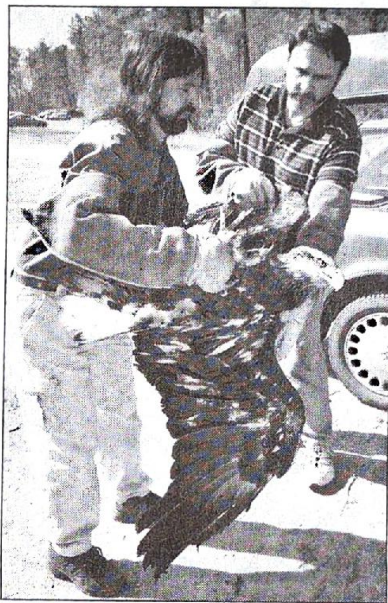
Bob got there and found a huge grill box on the lawn. When he lifted the box, he started going "Oh my God, oh my God," Barnhardt said. "Eagles are that rare."

The eagle released Sunday had been shot in the right wing, shattering two of its major bones. It beat the odds by living and thriving again, Barnhardt said.

Three other bald eagles have made it in recent years to the CRC, one of the top such rehab centers in the country. Only one still lives, and its condition is marginal.

"We rehab a lot of birds - 676 came in last year - but eagles are very, very unusual," Barnhardt said.

The mystery of the bird's injury is being investigated. The eagle was still very young - about 3 years old, in a life expectancy of up to 40 years - and didn't have the telltale white head and tail. But there is no



Mathias Engmann (left), director of rehabilitation at the Carolina Raptor Center, and Dr. Rick Beldegreen, prepare to release an American bald eagle that had been shot. Beldegreen's successful operation on the bird allowed for its full recovery. Bald eagles are a rarity in North Carolina - there are only 23 known pairs.

sporting bird that approaches the 6-foot-wingspan of a bald eagle, Barnhardt said. And there is a black market in eagle feathers, he said.

"It's doubtful this (shooting) was an accident," he said.

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Commission is continuing to investigate. A person convicted of harming a bald eagle faces a \$50,000 fine and a year in prison.

The birds have been protected since the 1970s by the Endangered Species Act and the Eagle Protection Act.

Almost extinct after years of hunting and DDT poisoning (in the fish that comprise the bulk of a bald eagle's diet), by the 1970s there were no bald eagles left in North Carolina.

Today, the state is home to 23 pair of bald eagles, Barnhardt said. "You'll see them mainly around the coast, because they are fish eaters, or along the wide major rivers and reservoirs," he said.

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survival because rapidly growing communities upstream in the Cape Fear basin are demanding larger shares of the water from Jordan Lake, which feeds the Cape Fear.

Cary and Apex, two fast-growing towns in Wake County, have asked the state to allow them to draw an extra 11 million gallons a day from the lake and discharge it into the Neuse River basin. The towns now draw 16 million gallons a day from Jordan Lake.

With added water demands elsewhere, damming the Cape Fear could be an option for meeting the Fayetteville area's future demands, said Mick Noland, the chief operating officer of water resources for the city's Public Works Commission. More study is needed to consider other alternatives, he said.

"Everybody would agree that what we need to do is assure our long-range water needs," Noland said.

The idea of a Cumberland County dam concerns some who live further downstream.

Mike Mallin, an ecologist at the University of North Carolina at Wilmington, said he opposes a dam because reduced flow in the river means more pollutants in water downstream.

"It's really going to become more and more difficult to get approval to do that because of the known detrimental effects to the ecosystem," said Mallin, who teaches river ecology.

A number of endangered fish species live in the Cape Fear, which would complicate such a dam project. Some species, including the American shad, swim up the river each year to spawn.

Dams are a final option to meet human water demands, said Wayne Wright of the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers in Wilmington.

sought for non-defense discretionary programs and Medicare and Social Security reform.

estates remaining subject to inheritance taxes. It was projected to cost \$40 billion over 10 years.

cal 2002 and beyond that allows tax cuts of \$1.2 trillion over 10 years, about \$400 hundred billion

billion for the drug benefit, but which would take about half of that sum not from the tax cut but